



Department of Political Science

SK2212 The Quality of Government in Comparative Perspective

Course Guide

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1. Introduction

This course explores problems of the quality of government (QoG) in a comparative perspective. Until a decade ago the "general wisdom" was that corruption and related phenomena (patronage, clientelism and cronyism) had many positive effects, such as, for example, "greasing the wheels". New theories and better data have turned this argument around. Corruption is now seen as having detrimental effects on economic growth, public goods provision, the viability of democratic processes and trust among citizens. Government organizations that are competent, impartial, uncorrupted and trustworthy are currently seen as one of the most important determinants of human well-being. Quality of government is not solely a problem of developing countries; it also affects economically advanced democracies, where trust in government institutions and the sustainability of welfare programs have been questioned. The central questions addressed in the course are: What is QoG? How is QoG related to democracy, good governance, rule of law, state capacity and other related concepts? What are the consequences of high/low QoG for individuals and societies? What are the mechanisms through which the effects of high/low QoG work? What explains the observed variation between countries in QoG? And What does it take for countries to change from low to high quality of government?

2. Learning Outcomes

A student who has passed the course will be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- Demonstrate in-depth knowledge of the concept of the quality of government, and distinguish it from related concepts
- Demonstrate in-depth knowledge of the impact of high/low quality government on human development
- Demonstrate in-depth knowledge of advanced theoretical frameworks on the causes of variation in quality government across countries

Competence and skills

- Critically evaluate and compare theoretical frameworks and empirical findings on the causes of variation in the quality of government.
- Identify contradictions, gaps, and under-researched areas in the existing literature and apply relevant frameworks to the analysis of empirical cases.

Judgement and approach

- Independently prepare an original piece of research about some central aspects of the QoG research agenda, based on a critical assessment of the literature
- Independently produce a text in accordance with the academic writing requirements
- Effectively communicate complex ideas to academic audience

3. Teachers

Marina Nistotskaya
Georgios Xezonakis
Victor Lapuente
Marcia Grimes

The QoG Institute, Department of Political Science (MN)
The QoG Institute, Department of Political Science (GX)
The QoG Institute, Department of Political Science (VL)
The QoG Institute, Department of Political Science (MG)

4. Organization of the Course

Teaching is conducted through lectures, compulsory seminars and individual tutorials. Language of instructions is English.

Lectures address one of the course's three overarching questions of the course: What is QoG? What are the effects of QoG? And What are the causes of QoG? The lectures provide an overview of key findings from the relevant scholarly literatures.

Seminars are conducted in small groups, which will be formed once the course administration has finalized the list of participants. There are six seminars in total.

Seminars 1-5 are discussion-based and focus on the readings assigned to each lecture (see the literature list below). The last seminar is devoted to student presentations of their final papers. Detailed information on seminar organization will be provided during the introductory lecture. students present their final paper. The organization of the seminars will be discussed during the introductory lecture.

Students are expected to complete all assigned readings. Active participation in seminar discussions and successful completion of written assignments require familiarity with the core arguments of the readings.

Seminar attendance is mandatory. Students who are unable to attend a seminar are required to submit a compensatory written memo that critically reviews the literature assigned for that session. The memo must be at least of 1,500 words. Compensatory work must be uploaded to Canvas (folder "Seminars: Compensatory Work") and submitted via Canvas email to the relevant seminar tutor.

Individual Tutorials. Students may contact the seminar tutors via Canvas email or schedule an appointment to address specific questions concerning the substantive seminar content and to discuss ideas for the final paper.

5. Assignments

Student performance is assessed through three written assignments: memo (1,5 credits), home-take exam (6 credits) and the final paper, which is a research-proposal (7,5 credits). All three written assessments have to be carried out individually.

Assignment 1: Memo (1,5 credits)

The goal of the assignment is to write a short critical essay “What is quality of government (QoG)? and how the concept of QoG is different from the concept of good governance”?

The memo shall be uploaded onto Canvas no later than **February 4, 2026, 17:00**. Queries about the memo shall be addressed to the relevant seminar tutor.

Detailed instructions for the memo can be found at the end of the course guide.

Assignment 2: Take-home exam (6 credits)

Take-home exam has two questions. Students are required to answer both questions.

In order to get a Pass for the take-home exam, students must get a pass grade for each question.

In order to get a High Pass for the take-home exam, students must get a High Pass grade for each question.

The exam questions will be posted on Canvas on **February 25, 2026 at 09:00am**. The answers shall be uploaded onto Canvas (2 individual folders, one per question) on **February 26 before 17:00**.

Georgios Xezonakis can be addressed with queries about the take-home exam.

Detailed instructions for the take-home exam can be found at the end of the course guide.

Exam Retake

Questions will be posted on Canvas in April 2026. Please check the schedule and the Canvas page for further information.

Assignment 3: Final Paper (7,5 credits)

The final paper is a research proposal about an under-researched issue in the QoG literature.

The final paper shall be uploaded onto Canvas on **March 20, 2026 before 17:00**.

Queries about the final paper shall be addressed to Marina Nistotskaya and Georgios Xezonakis.

Detailed instructions for the final paper can be found at the end of the course guide.

Assessment

The grading scale consists of High Pass, Pass and Fail.

To obtain a Pass grade for the course as a whole, students must achieve at least a pass grade for each individual assignment, and attended all compulsory seminars.

To receive a High Pass for the course as a whole, the student must obtain a High Pass in assignments worth at least 7,5 credits and a Pass in all remaining assignments.

To receive a High Pass the work of the student should demonstrate a very good knowledge on the main themes covered by the course and very good skills to connect theory and data through independent analyses and to fulfil high academic standards in terms of structure and language.

All assignments are checked for plagiarism.

The deadline for all submissions for missed seminars and assignments that did not meet the requirements for a passing grade (including the memo, take-home examinations, and the final paper) is **May 4th**. All materials must be uploaded to Canvas by this deadline.

Academic Writing

Throughout your time at University, you will write a number of academic texts (such as analytical papers and literature reviews, home exams and the final thesis). What follows are some of the basic principles for independent academic writing:

- Academic writing is based on the principle of clarity and transparency regarding the origin of the information and knowledge conveyed by the text.
- Academic texts are characterized by independent and self-designed writing.
- In combination, the above principles mean that in academic writing we use the ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions, conclusions of others, but we make clear the origin of these by quoting and referring. We communicate with, build on, and credit previous research, authors, sources, but we do not copy them! Copying is plagiarism, which is the same as cheating.
- Some examples of plagiarism: 1) Copying an existing text. 2) Moving and deleting a few words from an existing text, 3) Translating an existing text from another language. Please note that none of these examples qualify as legitimate academic writing regardless of whether a reference is present or if the text is presented as one's own description and / or analysis.
- There should be no doubt whatsoever in the text about which ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions and conclusions are yours (absent a reference) and which arguments you obtained from other texts (reference to the author included). There are different reference styles (see more about this at <http://www.ub.gu.se/skriva/referensstilar/>) but a good rule of thumb, for maximum transparency, is to include the reference in the text in the following form author surname, year, page, i.e. Sikkink 2000: 13.
- When an author you read uses particular wording to describe something, and you wish to use this exact wording in your text, this wording should be marked as a quote, with a reference that includes a page reference, such as (author surname, year, page). As stated, always including page numbers in the references in the text – whether cited or not – is a good rule of thumb!

- To put it simply, you avoid plagiarism by 1) writing independently (never ‘copy and paste’), 2) quoting, and 3) careful and frequent use of references.

- The Department of Political Science uses the Urkund control system against plagiarism. Our teachers are also very good at detecting texts that are not self-authored through our own critical reading experience. We are obliged to report suspicion of cheating to the Disciplinary Board at GU. Cheating can result in a warning or even a suspension from education.

Additional information on Searching and citing, Plagiarism, Language support and a web-course on Academic integrity is available at UoG:s student portal. All relevant information can be found under Student Portal > Student Environment & Rules > Disciplinary Matters.

Attempts to deceive during examinations

An attempt to deceive during examinations means that a student has attempted to give an impression of their performance in a written exam or some of form of assessment that is not true. That is what is commonly referred to as cheating or attempting to cheat. There are different kinds of attempts to deceive, such as plagiarism, prohibited aids and prohibited collaboration. Deception can also take other forms.

- **Plagiarism** means that a student has presented someone else’s text or other material as if it were their own text or material.
- **Prohibited aid** means that a student has used aids, including AI, that were not permitted according to the instructions.
- **Prohibited collaboration** means that students have collaborated with each other in breach of the instructions.

Plagiarism: Copying material from the Internet, from books, journals, reports, or from a fellow student and then presenting it as one’s own is strictly forbidden! Plagiarism is theft of someone else’s work and will result in immediate fail of the assignment. Please note that the inclusion of a source in a bibliography list is not in itself sufficient attribution of another’s work. In addition, unless it is a proper citation with a reference, any direct copying of text is forbidden. All submitted student work is screened with a program called *Ouriginal*, which compares a student’s written work with published materials (including everything published on the internet) and all the work from prior students, to detect plagiarism. The material you have read and based your arguments and factual statements on should always be referenced using proper referencing technique. More information on references and how to avoid plagiarism can be found here:

<https://studentportal.gu.se/english/help-and-guidance/search-read-write/reference-management-and-plagiarism>

Prohibited aid: All your submitted texts should be your own original writing, and not written by someone else or generated by AI. Unless there are specific instructions for the use of AI for an assignment, it should not be used and presented as your own text. The use of any tools to cheat during on campus exams (e.g. DISA) is also strictly forbidden.

Prohibited collaboration: students can discuss their work, but individual submissions must be your own original writing, and hence not too similar the work of others. Be extra careful to avoid using common notes from such collaborations.

Any kind of cheating on examinations is considered a serious offence. Proved or suspected cheating will be reported to the Disciplinary Committee of the University of Gothenburg, in accordance with the procedure of disciplinary matters at the department of political science.

The consequences may be severe for a student if found guilty. A student may be suspended from classes and campus for a determined time-period (from 3 weeks to half a year), which will result in a temporary suspension of all financial aid (including CSN) and may jeopardize a student's residence permit status. More information on disciplinary matters, including plagiarism and its consequences, can be found here: <https://studentportal.gu.se/english/study-environment-and-rules/disciplinary-matters/>

Equal Treatment

The University of Gothenburg aims to promote equal rights and opportunities for students and employees and to combat discrimination related to gender, gender identity or gender expressions, ethnicity, religion or other beliefs, sexual orientation, disability or age. If, however, you as a student at the Department of Political Science become subject to such acts and actions, we encourage you to contact us to enable the opportunity for appropriate action. You can contact: the course coordinator, director of studies Agness Cornell, equal treatment representative Valeria Mechkova, or student counselor Eva Nilsson. Student counselors are bound by confidentiality. You may contact them if you experience problems or discomfort in the study environment, even if the situation does not directly concern you. All relevant contact information is available on our website.

6. Schedule

The schedule is available at the Canvas's course page

<https://cloud.timeedit.net/gu/web/schema/ri1X5012Z1103vQQ5wZ6771Y07yY5Y27QQ.html>

Please check the Canvas page regularly during the course.

6. Literature List

All readings are available online through the University's subscription or will be uploaded onto Canvas.

For the entire course

Bågenholm, A., Bauhr, M., Grimes, M and B. Rothstein, Bo. 2021. *Oxford Handbook of the Quality of Government*. Chicago University Press. (available online through GU library).

Recommended:

The webpage of the Quality of Government Institute (<http://www.qog.pol.gu.se>), where QoG-related data and publications can be found.

What is Quality of Government?

Rothstein, Bo and Jan Teorell. 2008. What is Quality of Government: A Theory of Impartial Political Institutions, *Governance* 21(2):165-190.

Rothstein, Bo. 2021. Quality of Government: Theory and Conceptualization. In Bågenholm, Bauhr, Grimes and Rothstein (eds.) *The Oxford Handbook of the Quality of Government*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Pp. 3-24.

Agnafors, Marcus. 2013. Quality of Government: Toward a More Complex Definition, *American Political Science Review* 107(3): 433-445.

Nilsson, Joakim and Marina Nistotskaya. 2025. Legal Clarity and Impartiality: A Global Study of Consistency in Bureaucratic Decision-Making, [the Quality of Government Institute Working Paper series, 5](#)

Recommended:

Feldmann, H., 2025. The Quality of Government and Educational Performance Across Countries. *Economics & Politics*, [early view](#)

Sparling, Robert Alan. 2018. Impartiality and the Definition of Corruption. *Political Studies* 66(2): 376-391.

Charron, N. 2021. "Measuring the Unmeasurable? Taking Stock of QoG Measures." In A. Bågenholm, M. Bauhr, M. Grimes, and B. Rothstein (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of the Quality of Government*, Oxford: Oxford University Press. Pp. 93–114.

QoG: What do you get?

Nistotskaya, Marina. 2020. Quality of Government (QoG) as Impartiality: Review of the literature on causes and consequences of QoG, [KIPA \(Korean Institute of Public Administration\) Public Policy Review 1: 25-49](#).

Ahlerup, Pelle, Thushyanthan Baskaran, and Arne Bigsten. 2016. Government impartiality and sustained growth in Sub-Saharan Africa, *World Development* 83: 54-69.

Agerberg, Mattias. 2017. Failed expectations: Quality of government and support for populist parties in Europe, *European Journal of Political Research* 56(3): 578-600.

Recommended:

Oliveira, E., Abner, G., Lee, S., Suzuki, K., Hur, H. and Perry, J.L., 2024. What does the evidence tell us about merit principles and government performance? *Public Administration*, 102(2): 668-690.

Structural explanations 1: Geography, History, Colonialism, Institutional Persistence and QoG

Hibbs, Douglas and Ola Olsson. 2004. Geography, Biogeography, and Why Some Countries are Rich and Others are Poor, *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 101(10): 3715-3720.

Acemoglu, Daron, Johnson, Simon and James Robinson. 2002. Reversal of Fortune: Geography and Institutions in the Making of Modern World Income Distribution, *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 117(4): 1231-1294.

Becker, Sascha O., Katrin Boeckh, Christa Hainz, and Ludger Woessmann. 2016. The empire is dead, long live the empire! Long-run persistence of trust and corruption in the bureaucracy, *The Economic Journal* 126(590): 40-74.

Nunn, Nathan, and Leonard Wantchekon. 2011. The Slave Trade and the Origins of Mistrust in Africa, *American Economic Review* 101 (7): 3221-52.

Dell, Melissa. 2010. The Persistent Effects of Peru's Mining *Mita*, *Econometrica* 78(6): 1863-1903

Recommended:

Sachs, Jeffrey. 2003. Institutions don't rule: direct effects of geography on per capita income, National Bureau of Economic Research, *NBER Working papers series* No. w9490.
https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w9490/w9490.pdf

Structural explanations 2: Economic Structure and QoG

Economic structure and QoG

Olander, Petrus. 2019. Diversification, Homogeneity of Interests, and the Impartiality of Government. In Bågenholm, Bauhr, Grimes and Rothstein (eds.) *The Oxford Handbook of the Quality of Government*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, pp. 378-398.

Gawande, By Kishore, Pravin Krishna, and Marcelo Olarreaga. 2012. Lobbying Competition over Trade Policy, *International Economic Review* 53(1): 115-132.

Resource curse and QoG

Mehlum, Halvor, Karl Moene and Ragnar Torvik. 2006. Institutions and the Resource Curse, *Economic Journal* 115 (508): 1-20.

Sachs, Jeffrey and Andrew Warner. 2001. The Curse of Natural Resources, *European Economic Review* 45: 827-838.

Recommended:

Madison, J. 1788. The federalist papers No. 51.
<https://billofrightsinstitute.org/primary-sources/federalist-no-51>

Venables, Anthony. 2016. Using Natural Resources for Development: Why Has It Proven So Difficult? *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 30(1): 161–184.

Political explanations 1: Democracy and QoG

Bauhr, Monika and Marcia Grimes. Democracy and the Quality of Government. In Bågenholm, Bauhr, Grimes and Rothstein (eds.) *The Oxford Handbook of the Quality of Government*. Oxford: OUP, p. 181-208.

Bågenholm, Andreas. Electoral Accountability and Corruption. 2021. In Bågenholm, Bauhr, Grimes and Rothstein (eds.) *The Oxford Handbook of the Quality of Government*. Oxford: OUP, p. 181-208.

Povitkina M. 2018. The limits of democracy in tackling climate change. *Environmental politics* 27(3):411-32.

Recommended:

Charron, Nicholas and Victor Lapuente. 2010. Does Democracy Produce Quality of Government? *European Journal of Political Research* 49(4): 443-470.

Political Explanation 2: Merit-based Bureaucracy and QoG

Oliveira, E., Abner, G., Lee, S., Suzuki, K., Hur, H. and Perry, J.L., 2024. What does the evidence tell us about merit principles and government performance? *Public Administration*, 102(2): 668-690.

Kolvani, Palina, and Marina Nistotskaya. 2025. On mechanisms of meritocratic recruitment: competence and impartiality. *Journal of Institutional Economics* 21: e12.

Recommended:

Oliveros, Virginia, and Christian Schuster. 2018. Merit, Tenure, and Bureaucratic Behavior: Evidence from a Conjoint Experiment in the Dominican Republic, *Comparative Political Studies* 51(6): 759–92.

On re-politicization of bureaucracy

Yesilkagit, K., Bauer, M., Peters, B.G. and Pierre, J. 2024. The Guardian State: Strengthening the

public service against democratic backsliding. *Public Administration Review* 84(3): 414-425.

Recommended:

Bauer, Michael. 2025. Authoritarian drift, variegated paths: mapping administrative transformation strategies under illiberal rule. *Public Administration Review* 85(6): 1598-1610.

Kucinskias, Jaime, and Yvonne Zylan. 2023. Walking the moral tightrope: Federal civil servants' loyalties, caution, and resistance under the Trump administration. *American Journal of Sociology* 128(6): 1761-1808.

Political Explanations 3: Decentralization and QoG

Prud'homme, R. 1995. The Dangers of Decentralization, *The World Bank Observer* 10(2): 201-20

Fisman, Raymond, and Roberta Gatti. 2002. Decentralization and Corruption: Evidence Across Countries, *Journal of Public Economics* 83(3): 325-345.

Faguet, J-P. 2014. Decentralization and Governance, *World Development* 53:2-13

Smoke, P. 2015. Rethinking Decentralization: Assessing Challenges to a Popular Public Sector Reform, *Public Administration and Development* 35:97-112

Kyriacou, Andreas and Oriol Roca-Sagalés. 2011. Fiscal and Political Decentralization and Government Quality, *Environment and Planning C* 29: 204-223

Oto-Peralias, Daniel, Romero-Avila, Diego and Carlos Usabiaga. 2013. Does Fiscal Decentralization Mitigate the Effects of Corruption on Public Deficits? *European Journal of Political Economy* 32: 205-231

Recommended:

Oates, W. 1999. An Essay on Fiscal Federalism, *Journal of Economic Literature* 37(3): 1120-1149.

Faguet J-P. and F. Sanchez. 2008. Decentralization's Effects on Educational Outcomes in Bolivia and Colombia, *World Development* 36(7): 1294–1316.

Arends, Helge. 2020. The Dangers of Fiscal Decentralization and Public Service Delivery: a Review of Arguments, *German Political Science Quarterly* (Politische Vierteljahresschrift) 61: 599-622. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11615-020-00233-7>

Corruption: Theoretical Perspectives

Persson, Anna, Bo Rothstein and Jan Teorell. 2013. Why Anticorruption Reforms Fail: Systemic Corruption as a Collective Action Problem, *Governance* 26(3): 449-471.

Rothstein, Bo. 2011. Anti-corruption: the indirect 'big bang' approach. *Review of International Political Economy* 18(2): 228-250.

Khan, M., Andreoni, A., & Roy, P. 2019. Anti-corruption in adverse contexts: strategies for improving implementation. SOAS-Anti Corruption Evidence *Working paper 13*,
[https://eprints.soas.ac.uk/23495/1/Anti-Corruption%20in%20Adverse%20Contexts%20\(1\).pdf](https://eprints.soas.ac.uk/23495/1/Anti-Corruption%20in%20Adverse%20Contexts%20(1).pdf)

Pyman, M. & Heywood, P. (2020). The sector focus and reformulation approach (SFRA). *Global Integrity - ACE Working Paper 5*.
https://ca-anticorruption.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/12/The-Sector-FocusReformulation-Approach-_compressed-1.pdf

The World Bank. 2012. *Fighting Corruption in Public Services: Chronicling Georgia's Reforms* (available on Canvas)

Instructions

Assignment 1 (memo paper)

The aim of this assignment is to write a short critical essay addressing the following questions: “What is quality of government (QoG)? and how does the concept of QoG differ from the concept of good governance”?

The essay should include the following elements:

- 1. Introduction**

Provide a brief explanation of how you understand Quality of Government (QoG) and how it differs from the concept of good governance. Conclude the introduction with a sentence outlining the structure of your essay.

- 2. Main Section: Quality of Government (QoG)**

Discuss the concept of QoG in detail. Your discussion should be supported by references to the course literature—for example, Agnafors's (2013) critique of the original formulation by Rothstein and Teorell (2012)—as well as relevant real-world examples and/or counterfactuals (fictional scenarios).

- 3. QoG versus Good Governance**

Explain how the concept of QoG differs from the concept of good governance. Discuss why it is important to distinguish between these two concepts.

- 4. Conclusion**

Summarise your main arguments regarding QoG and its distinction from good governance.

Grading:

This assignment will be assessed based on the following criteria:

Understanding of the Literature

- Demonstrates a correct and thorough understanding of the key arguments presented in the relevant literature.
- Accurately represents authors' positions and debates discussed in the course materials.

Explanation of Key Concepts

- Clearly and effectively explains both concepts addressed in the assignment.
- Appropriately uses course materials, real-world examples, and/or counterfactuals to support explanations.

Conceptual Distinction

- Clearly explains why it is important to distinguish between the two concepts in question.
- Demonstrates an understanding of the analytical implications of this distinction.

Structure and Clarity

- The essay is well structured, logically organised, and clearly written.
- Ideas are presented coherently, with appropriate academic language and referencing.

Submission Requirements

- The assignment is completed on time and meets all specified requirements (e.g. word count, format, and submission guidelines).

The grading scale consists of High Pass, Pass and Fail.

Formalities:

- Max word count is 700 (including foot/end notes and in-text references, but excluding the reference list at the end of the memo).¹
- Line spacing: 1.5 lines.
- Font: size 12.
- The paper should be uploaded onto Canvas as a Word document, entitled “memo_ student’s last name” (memo_Olsson).
- The following information must be on the first page of the memo: last name, first name, course name (SK2212), assignment (memo) and word count.

Assignment 2 (take-home exam)

Take-home exam has two questions. Students are required to answer both questions. The exam questions will be posted on Canvas on **February 25, 2026 at 9 am**. The answers shall be uploaded onto Canvas (2 individual folders, one per question) before **17:00 on February 26, 2024**.

Grading:

This assignment will be assessed based on the following criteria:

Understanding of the Literature

- Demonstrates a correct and thorough understanding of the key arguments presented in the relevant literature.
- Accurately represents authors’ positions and debates discussed in the course materials.

Critical Evaluation

- Critically evaluates the strength of the theoretical explanations discussed.

¹ Papers that exceed the maximum word count by more than 10% will not be graded; and those papers that exceed the maximum word count up to 10% will be penalized by the loss of one point from the assignment grade.

- Assesses the quality and relevance of the empirical evidence used to support these explanations.

Structure and Clarity

- The essay is well structured, logically organised, and clearly written.
- Ideas are presented coherently, with appropriate academic language and referencing.

Submission Requirements

- The assignment is completed on time and meets all specified requirements (e.g. word count, format, and submission guidelines).

The grading scale consists of High Pass, Pass and Fail.

In order to get a Pass for the take-home exam each answer must achieve at least a pass grade on both questions.

In order to get a High Pass for the take-home exam, students must get a High Pass grade for each question.

Formalities:

- Max word count is 800 words per question (including foot/end notes and in-text references, but excluding reference list at the end of the final paper).²
- Line spacing: 1.5 lines.
- Font: size 12.
- Answers should be uploaded as a Word document.
- Each answer should be uploaded onto a separate folder on Canvas (your answer to question 1 should be uploaded into the folder “Question 1”, your answer to question 2 should be uploaded into the folder “Question 2”).
- Don’t put your name or other information that can identify you in the document. For each uploaded answer Canvas will generate a unique ID number, making your answers anonymous for the graders.

Assignment 3 (final paper)

The aim of this assignment is to write a research proposal that addresses an under-researched issue within the QoG field.

Your final paper should include the following elements:

1. Introduction

Present a QoG-related problem you intend to investigate. Explain why this problem is important from both an academic and a policy perspective.

2. Literature Review

² Answers that exceed the maximum word count by more than 10% will not be graded; and those answers that exceed the maximum word count up to 10% will be penalized by the loss of one point from the question grade.

Provide a critical discussion of the relevant literature on the chosen problem. This should include the main theoretical perspectives as well as the most important empirical findings.

3. Research Gap

Identify and discuss the limitations of the existing literature on your chosen problem. For example, explain how current scholarship has under-researched or overlooked a specific issue, factor or mechanism relevant to your problem.

4. Research Question

Formulate a clear and specific research question that directly stems from the identified gap in the literature.

5. Conclusion

Briefly discuss how addressing the identified gap would advance our understanding of the problem and contribute to the QoG literature and/or policy debates.

Synopsis:

Students are encouraged to email their seminar tutors a short synopsis (up to 200 words) describing their ideas for the final paper at least two days before the individual tutorial.

Grading:

Your assignment will be assessed based on the following criteria:

Literature Review

- Provides a comprehensive and coherent overview of the existing literature on the chosen issue.
- Accurately summarises key theoretical perspectives and empirical findings.

Identification of Research Gaps

- Clearly identifies limitations, gaps, or under-researched aspects of the existing literature.
- Effectively explains why these gaps matter for understanding the chosen issue.

Research Question

- Poses a clear, relevant, and well-defined research question that directly stems from the identified gap(s) in the literature.

Contribution to the Literature

- Convincingly explains how the proposed research would contribute to the existing literature.
- Demonstrates the potential theoretical and/or empirical value of the proposed study.

Structure and Clarity

- The proposal is well structured, logically organised, and clearly written.
- Arguments are presented coherently, using appropriate academic language and referencing.

Submission Requirements

- The assignment is completed on time and meets all specified requirements (e.g. word count, format, and submission guidelines).

The grading scale consists of High Pass, Pass and Fail.

Formalities:

- Max word count is 3,500 (including foot/end notes and in-text references, but excluding reference list at the end of the final paper).³
- Line spacing: 1.5 lines.
- Font: size 12.
- The paper should be uploaded onto Canvas as Word document, entitled “FP_student’s last name” (FP_Olsson).
- The following information must be on the first page of each document you upload onto Canvas: last name, first name, course name (SK2212), assignment (final paper) and word count.

³ Papers that exceed the maximum word count by more than 10% will not be graded; and those papers that exceed the maximum word count up to 10% will be penalized by the loss of one grade on the grading scale.